United Kingdom Liaison Mission in Japan,

TOKYO. — 24

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(1030/42/52)

28th January, 1952.

FJ 10310/37

Dear R.S.,

I do not know whether the Yoshida letter and its attendant issues are likely to be the subject of acrimonious debate in the House of Commons, but the press has reported that certain Labour Members have put down a motion.

The problem is, of course, yours, and I am not sure that either my despatch No. 15 of today's date or my letter 1030/38/52 of 27th January will have provided you with any ammunition. There are, however, two things I hope it will be possible to guard against. The first is quoting from Japanese sources that the Yoshida letter was due to American dictation. In fact, as I have indicated elsewhere, the Japanese themselves, for reasons of face, are anxious not to emphasise American dictation, and if they were put on the spot they would probably deny it officially and in public. So we can seek neither evidence nor comfort from that source.

The second is that we should not blame the Japanese in public for what Yoshida has done. They have been weak, and things might have been better handled, but it is after all not the Japanese who want to make a treaty with Chiang Kai-shek or to render it impossible to trade or have any relations with the mainland of China. Left to themselves I have no doubt they would have followed the course we thought they would follow, but they were not left to themselves. No doubt the Government will wish to avoid blaming the Americans in public for the sake of Anglo-American relations, and I hope they can also avoid blaming the Japanese for the sake of Anglo-Japanese relations.

I realise that this must leave you in Whitehall in rather a quandary as to what to say. But this, from my own Whitehall experience, is nothing new!

Yours ever,

Bill Fenning

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